

developers: the thing, described by the company as a Personal Air Vehicle, can be a car and a plane—it can change its configuration. Price (in 2009): \$148,000 (60 lakhs—not obscene by any standards). You drive it from your garage to the airstrip. Fuel: premium unleaded. Range: 160 to 800 km.

Then there's the Moller Skycar M400. Takes off and lands vertically like a chopper. Cruising speed 550 kmph; range 1,450 km. Almost exactly Bangalore to Bombay and back. (Sorry, old names—that's the way it is at indo.com, where we found the distance.) Initial cost: a million dollar-bucks. Mass-produced price *could* come down to \$60,000 (Rs 25 lakhs). Sounds too good to be true, but let's see. (We might have to see for a long time; it's been a while since Mr Moller began his experiments.) If you're shaking your head, you'll shake it more vigorously when you visit www.autoblog.com/2006/10/13/moller-skycar-makes-it-on-ebay. And if you've gotten excited, please don't visit www.spectrum.ieee.org/jan07/4835!

But do you seriously think neither of these—or none of those at the Wikipedia entry for Flying Cars—will take off (ooh!) sometime soon? Place your faith in German Engineering: both CEOs have Teutonic names...

The Good Stuff

Poor you: you didn't think jetpacks existed. Or you thought (blast these miserable clichés!) they existed only in science fiction...

Enter Jetpack International. Their site showcases the JetPack H202-Z, T-73, and more—promising names indicative of their sci-fi origins. About the T-73... price: 80 lakhs not including life insurance, flight time 19 minutes, speed 130 kmph, and it goes 250 feet into the air. (When it's released, *December this year*.) Text won't do all this justice: visit the site for pictures and videos. No hoax this: they've done it at shows. Caveat: you can't just strap it on and hover. One needs to have an Officially-Certified Aviation-Authority-Approved Major Qualification Certification to even think of strapping it on, or something to that effect. Watch the popular video at www.youtube.com/watch?v=THECWzrnciY—we know you'll think it's been doctored.

At www.jetpackinternational.com/video.html are plenty more detailed videos. But no word on when you'll be able to get one off the shelf.

"Terminator Hand hits North America" is the YouTube caption for www.youtube.com/watch?v=5MkJk6797mI. Watch the video. Now. It features the iLIMB, a prosthetic hand with five fingers—the special thing being they're individually powered. The tiny electric signals from the remaining portion of the limb power the thing, and *each individual finger* can open and close! "Terminator Hand"... nice caption, we say. Sci-Fa.

And some people are calling even *this* "baby steps."

Miscellany

This almost-just in: a real mineral with most of the chemical properties of kryptonite was discovered in Serbia, April of 2007—just five months ago. Pure magic, this... but we'll leave the wonder to you.



The iLIMB thingy holding a coin

Moon Base. Tiberius Station et al. You know. But NASA is indeed planning a permanent base on the Moon by the mid-2020s. This one was easy prediction, actually—the Moon isn't too far away, and we'd need Lebensraum at some point or the other. *Stephen Hawking*, incidentally, says humans won't survive if they don't re-engineer themselves and go into outer space! Now that's a current prediction—

Fi or Fa? Or Fo, or Fum?

And then there's an official definition of "Communicator" in *Star Trek: Enterprise*: "A portable Personal communications device. Communicators provide individuals a means of voice transmission from a planetary surface to an orbiting spacecraft or other nearby facility... Early versions of the communicator were compact handheld units with a flip-up antenna grid." Now here's something lovely, almost delicious: re-runs of *Enterprise* were on when people were already talking on their cell phones! And those phones were pretty much like those Communicators... and "Communicator" is even a brand name. Duh.

Then, stun guns: for real. Look at this: "It uses a temporary high voltage, low-current discharge to overcome the body's muscular mechanisms. The recipient feels great pain and can be temporarily paralysed. But since the amount of current is low it is supposed to be safe—it won't kill." From <http://gadgets-tech.blogspot.com/2007/07/stun-gun-science-fiction-or-reality.html>.

We live in interesting times.

And Now It's Down To...

...to some nonsense. At least, let's look at what seems like nonsense to us. There's mind downloading / uploading, a popular theme with sci-factors. The idea here is, quite simply, that you hook yourself up to an info-server of sorts and upload or download your brain's contents onto it / from it. (Britney Spears' brain could probably be uploaded onto a CD, but never mind.) What this entails is a complete mapping of the brain. Nanotech can do it, true. But each and every neuron? All that would take the computational powers of a zillion bajillion universes, assuming they exist. Sure, quantum computing might step in, but when? *Too* far into the future, sorry. Not happening.

Then there's all this stuff—all too common, all too cheap—about "different worlds." No, not parallel universes, which is a deep idea; we're saying so many writers just go into imaginary worlds where you can fertilise a woman over the phone and such. There's *Liquid Sky*, directed by Slava Tsukerman (1983), about heroin users in New York City; an alien spaceship lands in one apartment, and starts to kill people by growing crystals inside their head. Yes. It's got a 4/5 at Amazon. Bur cheap sci-fi predicts nothing.

We'll sign off with faster-than-light travel. College students smoking illegal substances discuss such stuff late into the night, voices raised. You can do it if you like. But It's Not Sci-Fa. ☒

ram_mohan@thinkdigit.com

